BLR's Human Resources Training Presentations

Delegation Techniques

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Speaker's Notes:

- This training session will focus on delegation techniques.
- The ability to delegate effectively is a core proficiency for managers and supervisors.
- The benefits of delegation are numerous and significant. They are well worth the effort it takes to ensure success.

Goals

- Recognize the value of delegation
- Understand the delegation process
- Realize the importance of giving and getting feedback
- Know why delegation can fail and how to prevent failure

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Speaker's Notes:

- First, we will talk about what delegation is and how you and your employees can benefit from it.
- Next, we will review the steps in the delegation process.
- Then, we'll discuss the importance of giving as well as getting feedback about delegated jobs.
- And we'll talk about why delegation can fail and how to prevent failure.
- Finally, we will wrap up the training session with a brief review, a summary, and quiz.

Delegation Defined

Delegation is:

- The assignment of responsibility and authority
- An essential supervisory skill
- A key time management technique
- An effective motivational tool

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Speaker's Notes:

- Before we talk about the benefits of delegation or how to make it work for you, we should take a moment to define exactly what we mean by delegation.
- Delegation is the assignment of responsibility and authority for tasks to employees.
- Delegation is an essential supervisory skill. Your job is essentially to get things done through others, so it's really all about delegation.
- Delegation is also a key time management technique, since it frees up more time for you to focus on managing the work rather than on actually performing tasks that can be done equally well by your employees.
- Finally, delegation is a highly effective motivational tool. It provides employees with challenges as well as opportunities for development and advancement.

How Delegation Benefits You

- Helps get the work done
- Allows you to focus on tasks only you can do
- Makes the best use of abilities
- Encourages greater participation
- Builds a more competent and motivated team

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Speaker's Notes:

- Delegation benefits you in several important ways.
- It helps you accomplish all the tasks for which you're responsible. As we all know only too well, in your job there's usually more to do than time in which to do it.
- Delegation also allows you to focus your time and energy on those tasks that only you can do.
- Furthermore, it makes the best use of your group's abilities.
- Delegation also creates a work environment in which participation is valued and encouraged.
- And it helps you build a more competent and motivated team.

How Delegation Benefits Your Employees

- Shows trust and confidence
- Develops skills
- Provides broader experiences
- Motivates
- Facilitates advancement

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Speaker's Notes:

- Delegation also benefits your employees in many ways.
- It shows trust and confidence in their abilities and judgment.
- It encourages employees to develop varied skills and expand on the knowledge they already have.
- Delegation provides broader experiences, which allow employees to look beyond their own jobs and responsibilities and see the big picture.
- Delegation motivates employees by providing them with challenges and helping them achieve career goals.
- Finally, it helps prepare them for advancement.

Delegation Is a Six-Step Process

1. Determine the task
2. Define the task
3. Select the right person for the job
4. Explain the task
5. Monitor progress and provide support
6. Follow up

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Speaker's Notes:

- Delegation is basically a six-step process.
- The first step is to determine which tasks to delegate.
- Step two is to define the task clearly in your own mind.
- Step three is to select the right person for the job.
- Step four is to explain the task thoroughly and clearly.
- Step five is to monitor progress and provide support.
- And step six is to follow up and make sure the task has been successfully completed.

Step One: Determine the Task

- Similar to the work employees already do
- Clearly defined procedures and results
- Repetitive
- Development-oriented
- Tasks that can't be delegated

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Speaker's Notes:

- Now let's take a closer look at each step, beginning with step one, determining the task or tasks to delegate.
- Generally, a task can be delegated if it's similar to tasks already being performed by your employees.
- Tasks that have clearly defined procedures and results are also good candidates for delegation.
- Tasks that are repetitive, involving the same skills and activities throughout, are also easily delegated.
- You should also consider delegating tasks that help employees develop new skills and have new work experiences. Jobs like these help employees develop professionally and prepare them for advancement. Of course, with development-oriented tasks, you'll probably need to provide more training and support.
- Tasks generally can't be delegated successfully if they are of a sensitive or confidential nature, such as salary and performance reviews, or if they're not clearly defined and have vague procedures and uncertain end results.

Step Two: Define the Task

- What the task is
- Why it's being done
- How important it is
- What distinct activities are involved
- Which standards must be met

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Speaker's Notes:

- The second step is to define the task in your own mind so that you can communicate it effectively. There are several things you need to know about a job before you can delegate it successfully.
- First, you need to be certain about what the task you're delegating really is. Are you simply asking the employee to file papers from your overflowing in-basket, for example, or are you asking the employee to *decide* what to file as well as doing the actual filing itself. There's a big difference in the training required to complete those two different tasks.
- You also need to be prepared to explain why the task is being done. What is its purpose? What is the goal? This will help the employee understand the job better. It's also motivational. People like to know why they're doing things.
- You must decide how important the job is. This affects the timetable you set as well as the standards that must be met and the support you'll need to provide. It also gives the employee a more complete understanding of the job and how it should be done.
- Although you generally try to leave the details of execution up to the employee when you delegate, you should have a clear idea of the distinct activities involved in the task so that you can be sure the employee you select is capable of handling all the different activities involved.
- You must also determine the standards that must be met for the job to be successfully completed.

Step Two: Define the Task (cont.)

- When it needs to be finished
- Where to report
- How to know when the job's finished
- Which resources can be used
- What training and coaching is needed

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Speaker's Notes:

- Before you can delegate a task, you need to decide when the job must be finished so that you can set up a reasonable timetable.
- You also have to think about to whom the employee should report. It may be to you, or it may be to another employee, or even to another supervisor, depending on the job you're delegating.
- How will the employee know when the job is done? What is the exact result you're looking for?
- Which people, materials, equipment, and tools can the employee use to complete the task?
- Finally, you must consider what training and coaching will be necessary for successful completion of the delegated task and how the employee will get it. Will you provide necessary training and coaching yourself, or will that task also be delegated?

Step Three: Select the Right Person

- Match the person to the task
- Don't always choose the most qualified
- Consider professional development needs

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Speaker's Notes:

- Once you've decided what to delegate and what needs to be done, you're ready to choose the person to do it.
- You want to match the person to the task and choose the best person for the job.
- But choosing the best person for the job doesn't always mean selecting the person who can do it best. If only experts do the job, only experts will know how to do it—and eventually you'll run low on experts.
- An important part of your job is developing your employees. Delegation is a great way to do that. People grow when they have a challenge.

Step Four: Explain the Task

- Information
- Training
- Resources
- Expectations
- Authority

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Speaker's Notes:

- Now comes the important step of communicating with the employee you've selected for the task.
- Begin by making it clear exactly what the task is, why it needs to be done, why you selected the employee, and the benefits he or she will gain from doing the job.
- If the task requires special training, tell the employee how and when training will be provided.
- Also tell the worker about any resources that will be available—people, materials, equipment, etc.—and how to find those resources.
- Be sure to make your expectations clear as well. If you want a five-page report, say so. If you expect invoices to be filed by number rather than by the name of the customer, be sure to communicate that information. Don't just say, "Here, file these."
- You also need to make it clear how much authority you are delegating. Will the employee have to ask for approval every step of the way, or are you giving the worker permission to decide for himself or herself how the task will be accomplished? Make sure both the employee and others understand the scope of the authority you're delegating.

Step Four: Explain the Task (cont.)

- Deadline
- Completion
- Questions
- Confirmation

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Speaker's Notes:

- An important part of this fourth step in the delegation process is setting a realistic deadline for completion of the job—or better yet, arriving at a mutually agreed upon deadline with the employee. The deadline should allow extra time for delays and unexpected events. Stress the importance of keeping on schedule. Setting checkpoint, or midpoint, deadlines at various stages of the job can help the employee stay on schedule and meet the final deadline on time.
- Make sure the employee will know when the job is completed. With some jobs this might be obvious. But with others, it might not be as clear, and you will need to explain. For example, is a filing job done when your in-basket is empty at the end of the day, or is this meant to be an ongoing task that will need to be done on a daily basis? If you delegate the task of orienting a new employee, is that job done at the end of a few weeks? Or is completion contingent on how quickly the new employee learns?
- Be sure to encourage questions—either throughout your explanation or at the end. That way you'll be able to fill in gaps in understanding and clarify any points on which the employee was not absolutely clear.
- Finally, confirm what you have just discussed with the employee so that you know the employee is clear about expectations and understands the what, when, where, why, and how of the job you're delegating.

Step Five: Monitor Progress And Provide Support

- Don’t hover
- Schedule meetings or reports
- Loosen the reins
- Delegate the right to do things differently
- Offer help only if it’s needed

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Speaker’s Notes:

- As the employee works at the delegated task, be sure to monitor progress and provide necessary support.
- Monitoring progress doesn’t mean hovering over the employee as if waiting to pounce on every mistake. Employees are more likely to fumble the ball if they sense they’re constantly being watched.
- A good way to monitor without hovering is to schedule meetings with the employees or ask for periodic reports. This way you can keep on top of the job without having to constantly look over the employee’s shoulder. In between meetings or reports, you can ask informal questions to show interest and get an idea of how the job is coming.
- Loosen the reins and give the employee the chance to learn and experiment with new ways of doing things.
- When you delegate, you also delegate the right to do things differently from the way you might do them. Yes, it’s possible that an employee will make a mistake. But that’s part of the risk you take when you delegate. It’s also part of the process. People often learn more by making mistakes than they do by doing a job perfectly the first time.
- Offer help—but only if it’s needed. Allow employees the experience of meeting challenges and handling problems on their own to the extent possible. If you do feel you have to step in at some point, try to offer advice rather than issue orders. And as soon as the employee is back on his or her feet, step back and allow the employee to proceed on his or her own again.

Step Six: Follow Up

- Review results
- Review performance
- Review the delegation process itself

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Speaker's Notes:

- The sixth and final step in the delegation process is to follow up with a complete review.
- Begin by reviewing the results of the assignment. Was the job successfully completed? If not, why not? Did the employee lack necessary skills? Did you fail to explain the job well enough? Were resources inadequate? Did the employee lack confidence?
- Next, review the employee's performance. Did he or she do a good job, a poor job, just an adequate job, or an excellent job? Again, look at why.
- And don't forget to review the delegation process itself. How might you improve the way the assignment was delegated so that a better result can be achieved next time?

Giving Positive Feedback

- Make it specific and use examples
- Describe what was done well
- Reinforce the behavior you want
- Explain the result or effect
- Be timely

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Speaker's Notes:

- Giving employees positive feedback while they work on delegated tasks and after the task is completed is essential.
- Make your feedback specific. Base it on a specific event, behavior, action, etc. Also, use examples to make your feedback more useful.
- Describe what was done well. For example, "You really did an excellent job of cleaning up the bins and resorting the parts."
- Reinforce the behavior you want repeated. For example, "Your thorough review of the customer's complaint saved the account."
- Explain the result or effect of the employee's actions or behavior. For example, "Thanks to the extra time you put in, we were able to meet the deadline."
- Be timely with your feedback. To be most effective, positive reinforcement needs to come as soon after the event, behavior, action, etc., as possible.

Correcting Performance

- Focus on the work, not the person
- Identify problem areas
- Explain how to improve
- Agree on a plan of corrective action
- Continue to monitor and provide feedback on progress

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Speaker's Notes:

- Sometimes instead of offering praise, your feedback will need to correct performance.
- Whenever you need to correct an employee's work, be sure to focus on the work, not the person. Avoid putting the employee on the defensive.
- Without placing blame, identify problem areas, work that was done poorly, mistakes that were made, and so forth.
- Explain in detail how the employee can improve performance.
- Agree on a plan of action for turning your feedback into positive performance.
- Continue to monitor the employee's performance and provide feedback on progress.

Getting Feedback

- Let employees know you want their feedback
- Encourage two-way communication
- Act on feedback
- Keep employees informed

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Speaker's Notes:

- Of course, when you delegate a task, you not only need to give feedback to the employee, you must also get feedback from the employee so that you have a good idea how the job is progressing.
- When you delegate tasks, be sure to let employees know that you want their feedback while they're working on the job. Make sure they understand that you want to be kept informed of progress, problems, etc.
- Encourage two-way communication by listening to employees when they come to you to discuss a delegated job. Make time for them, and pay attention to what they're saying.
- One excellent way to let employees know that you value their feedback is to act on it. By using the information they are giving you, you let them know that it's important, and you encourage them to keep you informed in the future. For example, if an employee comes to you and tells you that there is a problem with equipment needed to complete a delegated task, get the equipment fixed or make sure the employee has a suitable alternative. If an employee comes to you with a suggestion for streamlining a job or improving quality, let the employee put those suggestions into effect, if possible.
- Finally, if you keep employees well informed, they are likely to do the same for you. When you make the effort to provide them with the latest information, they'll return the favor.

Why Delegation Fails

- It's got to be perfect
- My way or the highway
- Fear of failure
- Inability to let go

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Speaker's Notes:

- There are a number of reasons delegation might fail. This first set concerns the supervisor.
- Delegation will probably fail if the supervisor is a perfectionist. To begin with, perfectionists have a hard time turning responsibility for a result over to someone else. And then, they are usually dissatisfied with the outcome unless they do it themselves or unless they've micro-managed the task every step of the way. And, of course, that's not what delegation is all about. Most jobs don't need to meet some ideal of perfection. They need to meet required standards, and if those are met, the delegation was successful.
- Delegation is also likely to fail when supervisors think there's only one right way to do a job—their way. Delegation involves allowing employees the leeway to determine how the job should be done and giving them the authority to carry out the task with minimal supervision.
- Fear of failure is another reason delegation fails. Many supervisors fear that employees will make mistakes or be unable to meet standards for a task, and therefore they are reluctant to delegate work. Failure is a possibility, of course. But it's not likely if the employee is properly trained, given sufficient resources, and adequately monitored and supported.
- Delegation also generally fails when a supervisor just can't let go of control over the task. Some supervisors like doing a particular task, so they don't want to delegate it. Others feel they have to keep their skills sharp, so they do a job themselves that could easily be done by one of their employees. Still other supervisors feel that they shouldn't ask employees to do a job that they don't want to do themselves. Or they might have the misguided notion that they have to set an example for employees by doing the work rather than what they really should be doing, which is supervising it.

Why Delegation Fails (cont.)

- Lack of training
- Lack of confidence
- Lack of motivation
- Lack of resources or support

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Speaker's Notes:

- Delegation can also fail if an employee isn't prepared to do the task or if the wrong employee is chosen for the job.
- Failure is almost guaranteed when an employee lacks necessary skills, and information to do a good job and adequate training to make up for this deficiency has not been provided.
- Delegation can also fail if an employee lacks the confidence to work on his or her own and take responsibility for making decisions about a task. These employees can still succeed with delegated tasks, however, if you start slow, delegating easy, small tasks, and providing a lot of support and encouragement. When they're ready, you can give them more responsibility, thereby slowly building their confidence.
- Without proper motivation, delegation often fails. Unless you help employees look upon delegated tasks as challenges that will help them grow and advance, they may just look on them as extra work you are dumping on them because you don't want to do it yourself.
- Lack of resources or support can also cause delegation to fail. You need to make sure before you delegate a task what resources will be needed and ensure their availability at the right time. And although you don't want to be constantly looking over the employee's shoulder, you do want to keep the lines of communication open and be prepared to offer advice, assistance, and encouragement as needed.

Building on Success

- Give employees credit for accomplishments
- Tell others about their achievements
- Use the results to help employees grow and improve

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Speaker's Notes:

- Delegation helps your employees to grow and develop and helps you to manage more effectively. And if you can avoid the kinds of problems we've just discussed, success usually builds on success.
- To build on the success of delegated tasks, give employees credit for their accomplishments. Let them know that you appreciate their effort and are proud of their work. This will heighten their enthusiasm for taking on more responsibility in the future.
- Tell others in the group and in the organization about the achievements of employees to whom you've successfully delegated work. This will encourage other employees to become more involved and more eager to take on new challenges.
- Use the results of delegation to help employees grow and improve. Provide them with more and more challenging work with each subsequent job you delegate.

Review: Delegation Do's

- Demonstrate trust and confidence in employees
- Select tasks carefully
- Keep employees' other responsibilities in mind
- Consider their interests and ambitions
- Explain the task clearly and completely
- Provide resources and authority

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Speaker's Notes:

- Now let's review what we've discussed with these delegations do's and don'ts.
- Demonstrate trust and confidence in employees by delegating.
- Select tasks for delegation carefully.
- Keep employees' other responsibilities in mind when delegating.
- Consider employees' interests and ambitions.
- Explain what's being delegated clearly and completely.
- Provide the necessary resources and authority.

Review: Delegation Do's (cont.)

- Allow employees leeway
- Set goals, timetables, and standards
- Establish a method for monitoring progress
- Give employees credit for accomplishments
- Encourage them to come to you with questions
- Work with employees on corrective action when necessary

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Speaker's Notes:

- Allow employees leeway in determining how to execute a delegated task.
- Set goals, timetables, and standards for delegated tasks.
- Establish a method for monitoring progress.
- Give credit to employees for their accomplishments with delegated tasks.
- Encourage them to come to you with questions or to discuss delegated assignments.
- Work with employees on corrective action when delegated tasks fall behind or go astray, and increase your level of support.

Review: Delegation Don’ts

- Don’t do everything yourself
- Don’t delegate tasks that involve delegation
- Don’t delegate when confidential information is involved
- Don’t overload your most competent workers
- Don’t overload workers who don’t complain

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Speaker’s Notes:

- Now for the delegation don’ts.
- Don’t think that a job won’t be done properly unless you do it yourself.
- Don’t delegate tasks that involve delegating work to others. Only delegate tasks to an employee that an employee can do himself or herself.
- Don’t delegate tasks that involve sensitive or confidential information meant for your eyes only.
- Don’t overload your most competent employees.
- Don’t overload workers just because they are the least likely to complain.

Review: Delegation Don’ts (cont.)

- Don’t override an employee’s authority
- Don’t take credit for delegated tasks
- Don’t downplay accomplishments
- Don’t micromanage or second-guess
- Don’t remove employees from delegated tasks

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Speaker’s Notes:

- Don’t override an employee’s authority when you delegate unless there is an insurmountable problem that can be solved only with your intervention.
- Don’t take credit for an employee’s accomplishments with a delegated assignment.
- Don’t downplay or dismiss an employee’s accomplishments.
- Don’t micromanage or second-guess the activities of employees engaged in delegated tasks.
- Don’t remove an employee from a delegated task unless corrective action and support fail.

Goals

- Recognize the value of delegation
- Understand the delegation process
- Realize the importance of giving *and* getting feedback
- Know why delegation can fail and how to prevent failure

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Speaker's Notes:

- Are there any questions concerning delegation techniques?
- Let's wrap up this training session with a summary and a quiz.

Summary

- Delegation allows you to be more efficient and productive
- It builds employees' skills, knowledge, and confidence
- Delegation helps motivate employees and encourages participation

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Quiz

1. How would you define delegation?
2. Delegating involves directing an employee to perform a task in the same way you would if you had the time. True or False
3. Name three ways delegation can benefit you.
4. Name three ways delegation can benefit your employees.

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Background for the Trainer:

- Remind participants that the quiz is to encourage further discussion and to ensure that everyone understands what was discussed.

Quiz (cont.)

5. If a delegated task starts to fall behind schedule, the best thing to do is to step in and take over the task.
   True or False
6. Name the six steps in the delegation process.
7. When you need to correct an employee's performance concerning a delegated task, you should identify problem areas, explain how to improve, _____, and _____.

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Quiz (cont.)

8. When you follow up on a delegated job, you need to review _____, _____, and _____.
9. Name three steps you can take to encourage employees to give you feedback about delegated tasks.
10. Delegation can fail if the supervisor can't let go of control or fears the employee will be unable to do a good job. **True or False**

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Quiz Answers

1. Delegation is the assignment of responsibility and authority for tasks to employees. It is an essential supervisory skill and a key time management technique. It is also an excellent motivational tool.
2. False. You should communicate goals, purpose, timetable, etc., but allow the employee as much leeway as possible in determining how to perform the task.

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Quiz Answers (cont.)

3. Delegation benefits you by making the best use of employees' abilities, helping you to get the work done, allowing you to focus on tasks only you can do, encouraging greater participation by employees, and building a more competent and motivated team.
4. Delegation benefits employees by showing trust and confidence in their abilities and judgment, developing their skills, providing broader experiences, motivating them, and preparing them for advancement.

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Quiz Answers (cont.)

5. False. You should work with the employee to come up with a corrective action plan that will get the job back on schedule.
6. The six steps of the delegation process are (1) determine the task, (2) define the task, (3) select the right person for the job, (4) explain the task, (5) monitor progress and provide support, and (6) follow up.

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Quiz Answers (cont.)

7. In addition to identifying problem areas and explaining how to improve, you should agree on a plan of corrective action with the employee and continue to monitor performance and provide feedback on progress. And always focus on the work, not on the person.
8. When you follow up on a delegated job, you need to review results, performance, and the delegation process itself.

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Quiz Answers (cont.)

9. You can encourage employees to give you feedback about delegated jobs by letting them know you want their feedback, encouraging two-way communication by making time to discuss problems, questions, etc.; acting on employee feedback; and keeping employees informed, which will prompt them to keep you informed.
10. True. Delegation is also likely to fail when supervisors are perfectionists or think their way is the only way to do the job.

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